Harborway Welcome Center

English, job skills, and a first friend for newcomers

STATUS	501(c)(3) public charity, Connecticut
FOUNDED	2011
BASED IN	Wooster Square, New Haven (classrooms in a parish hall)
SERVES	Adult immigrants and refugees across Greater New Haven
ANNUAL BUDGET	About $205,000
STAFF	Program director, ESL coordinator, part-time job coach
VOLUNTEERS	About 70 volunteer tutors
REACH	About 260 adult learners per year from more than 30 countries

MISSION

Harborway helps newcomers build English, find good work, and feel at home in their new community.

OUR STORY

Harborway began as a Saturday English class taught by four retired teachers for families resettled in New Haven. As more newcomers arrived, it added evening classes, one-on-one tutoring, and job readiness support.

WHO WE SERVE

Adults ages 18–65, including refugees, asylum seekers, and immigrant workers. Education levels range from no formal schooling to doctors and engineers whose credentials aren't recognized here.

PROGRAMS

English for Everyday Life
Evening and Saturday classes at four levels, 6 hours a week, in 12-week terms.

Conversation Partners
Each learner who wants one is paired with a volunteer for weekly conversation over coffee.

Work Ready
An eight-week course on resumes, interviews, and workplace English, plus job coaching and connections to local employers.

HOW WE'RE FUNDED

A state adult education sub-grant (35%), foundations (30%), individual donors and a spring dinner (25%), and employer partners (10%).

WHAT WE TRACK TODAY

The state grant requires a standardized English test at entry and after 40 hours, and enrollment and attendance reported in a state system. Job placements are tracked informally by the job coach.

WHAT WE'RE WRESTLING WITH

The required test shows English gains, but learners say the biggest change is confidence and feeling less isolated. Staff want to show that, and to track job outcomes more consistently.

A MOMENT FROM OUR WORK

A former pharmacist from Afghanistan practiced pharmacy vocabulary with her conversation partner every week. She was hired as a pharmacy technician and now volunteers to teach the Work Ready health-careers session. (Details changed to protect privacy.)